The Curtain Falls

In Berlin, events now moved with dramatic swiftness. Krenz's plotters – with the blessing of Gorbachev – moved to decisively eject Honecker and chart a new course. In classic SED fashion, the final act played out at a routine Politburo meeting the following morning, 17 October, when Willi Stoph interrupted Honecker's opening statement to propose a motion that 'Comrade Honecker be relieved of his function as General Secretary.'1 Although dumbfounded by the abruptness, Honecker quickly composed himself but was sickened that none of his colleagues had had the decency to speak with him beforehand. 'I gave the floor to the comrades, one after another.' There were no scathing indictments, but Kurt Hager uneasily explained that trust in intellectual circles had vanished under his leadership, while Inge Lang, Siegfried Lorenz and Margaret Muller spoke especially sharply. 'All the comrades with one or another reason, including Günter Schabowski, said it was a very hard decision I had to grasp.'2 The most fiery speech of all, came from Erich Mielke. As his mouth tightened, the Stasi boss dangled the prospect of releasing a cache of documents concerning Honecker's indiscretions and moral laxity if he did not resign voluntarily (Mielke had 'trustworthy colleagues' stationed outside the Politburo in case Honecker attempted to have his personal bodyguard arrest the plotters).3

Having vented, Mielke handed the floor to Honecker's supposed anointed crown prince, Egon Krenz. His eyes circled and puffy, he declared 'this was a decisive moment', and after 'considering the matter very carefully' agreed to the SED leader's removal. He later said he felt an odd tenderness towards Erich, which made the episode difficult. At the same meeting, Honecker's oldest pals and veterans of many bitter battles, Günter Mittag, and propaganda head, Joachim Herrmann, were also relieved of their posts.

The First Secretary didn't defend himself and there was no further business. 'A certain liberation took place,' Honecker reflected. 'I felt no kind of desire to continue to work in the kind of collective that had pushed for my